

The Gospel of the Egyptians

Codex Reference: III,2 and IV,2 **Translated by:** Alexander Böhlig and Frederik Wisse **Source:** Robinson, J.M. (ed.), *The Nag Hammadi Library in English*, 3rd rev. ed. (HarperSanFrancisco, 1990), p. 208ff.

Editor's Introduction

Introduced and translated by Alexander Böhlig and Frederik Wisse

The so-called Gospel of the Egyptians is preserved in two Coptic versions which were translated independently from the Greek. It is not related to the apocryphal Gospel of the Egyptians which is cited in Patristic literature. The tractate, which is also entitled "The Holy Book of the Great Invisible Spirit," is an esoteric writing representing a Sethian type of mythological Gnosticism. It may be described as a work which presents a gnostic salvation history. Since the mythological, heavenly Seth is portrayed as the father of the gnostic race, it is appropriate that the tractate lists him as the author of this divinely inspired book.

The tractate is divisible into four main sections. The first section (III 40,12-55,16 = IV 50,1-67,1) deals with the origin of the heavenly world: from the supreme God, dwelling in solitary height as the transcendent Great Invisible Spirit, there evolves and emanates a series of glorious beings, from the mighty trinity of Father, Mother Barbelo, and Son, through the pleroma of heavenly powers, to Adamas' great son Seth, the father and savior of the incorruptible race. The second section (III 55,16-66,8 = IV 67,2-78,10) discusses the origin, preservation, and salvation of the race of Seth: because of the arrogance and hostility of Saklas and the Archons, Seth comes from heaven, puts on Jesus as a garment, and accomplishes a work of salvation on behalf of his children. The third section (III 66,8-67,26 = IV 78,10-80,15) is hymnic in character; and the fourth section (III 68, 1-69,17 = IV 80,15-81,end) contains a concluding account of the Sethian origin and transmission of the tractate.

Thus, in a manner analogous to that in which the New Testament gospels proclaim the life of Jesus, The Gospel of the Egyptians presents the life of Seth. His pre-history, the origin of his seed, the preservation of his seed by the heavenly powers, the coming of Seth into the world, and his work of salvation, especially through baptism, are proclaimed with drama and praise.

The following translation is based primarily on the text of Codex III; the more fragmentary (though probably more reliable) text of Codex IV has been utilized for the missing pages 45-48, and when the text of III,2 appears to be corrupted.